HQ 79 Mountain Brigade, the Himalayan brigade, was located at Khreuh, about 25 kilometres from Srinagar. I took over from Brigadier K.C. Dhingra at a time when the people were restive, and the feeling that 'azaadi' (freedom) was round the corner was gaining currency. Massive demonstrations by people chanting 'azaadi' slogans were the order of the day. This Machiavellian plan of Pakistan to wrest control of Kashmir was kept as a closely guarded secret. It was an unconventional war with an avowed aim of bleeding India by a thousand cuts. During the Indo-Pak war of 1965, Pakistan infiltrated a trained guerrilla force, including officers and soldiers from the regular army, for carrying out acts of sabotage, violence and subversion in Kashmir as part of Operation Gibraltar. This operation was an unmitigated disaster due to the effective response of the Indian Army, and also because Pakistan's action received no support from the Kashmiri people.

Therefore, this time, as part of Operation Topac, Pakistan planned to train and indoctrinate Kashmiri youth and subvert the system from within. In the next phase, the aim was to destabilize the state administration with low-level insurgency and keep the Indian Army engaged by small-scale attacks in vulnerable areas. In the third phase, Pakistan hoped to carry out large-scale infiltration and armed action to grab Kashmir.

In actual fact, by 1990, a large number of young men had been given training and indoctrinated with jehadi ideology, and a fair amount of subversion of the state administration had already been achieved. In particular, this included some politicians, elements of the police, public health engineering, telecom, and forest departments. Infiltration across the LoC was being reported from many areas. And an extremely violent phase of Kashmir's history was beginning to unfold. Phases 2 and 3 had not taken off until then. Nonetheless, the jehadis carried out ethnic cleansing by forcing about three lakh Kashmiri pundits to flee the valley. Farooq Abdullah's government fell and the state remained under president's rule from January 1990 to October 1996. Thereafter, Farooq Abdullah was again elected and was chosen to lead the National Conference government till October 2002.